REFRESH · PUBLIC-SERVING DIVISION · REACH GRANT PROGRAM

REACH: Business Case and Strategic Launch Path

A self-paced guide for the Refresh executive team. It explains what the public-serving division is building, the frameworks the plan rests on, how the model compounds, how we measure it, and the strategic bet underneath all of it.

Self-paced study · about a 15-minute read · written to be read straight through, at your own pace

How to use this. This is a study document rather than a slide deck, and it needs no presenter. Read it from top to bottom at whatever pace suits you. By the end you should be able to explain, in your own words, what the public-serving division is building, why the model works, how we will measure it, and what we are protecting. A companion slide version exists for live sessions. There is also a **PDF of this study** if you would rather read it on paper or pass it on.

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SECTION 1

What we are building

The public-serving division of Refresh runs REACH, a white-labeled engagement and orchestration platform that trusted nonprofits deliver to the people and communities they serve. It sits on top of the benefits, resources, programs, and services that already exist but remain scattered across disconnected systems, and it brings the right tool, benefit, or resource to each person at the right moment.

Before going further, hold on to the shape of the thing.

> **One REACH network. Many white-label front doors. One portable person account. One commons every partner tends.** Nonprofits get their own branded app, which is the front door. Underneath, every one of those apps runs on the same REACH platform, which is the network. Every person has a single REACH account that belongs to them, not to the organization they came in through. And every partner's local knowledge lands in one collection that all of them draw from.

> **A note on naming.** Three things carry names here, and we keep them separate on purpose. **Refresh** is the company and the platform technology, the engine everything runs on. The **neutral consumer app**, shown throughout this study as REACH for illustration, is the app a person keeps, and its final name is a branding decision still to be made, so it could be REACH or Refresh. Each organization's **white-label app** carries that organization's own name, for example Goodwill Marion, powered by the platform. Whatever we name the consumer app, it is a distinct product from the platform technology beneath it, and commercial peers already ship white-labeled apps of their own in the app stores.

Public and private organizations have already invested heavily in apps of their own, and we are not asking them to throw that away. We are giving those doors a shared floor to stand on. Once a person arrives through an organization's own Refresh white-label portal, whether they came to be served or to serve, they are part of the ecosystem, free to use services and to contribute to them anywhere in the network and at any time. The investment each organization already made stops being a silo and starts being an entrance.

That collection is what makes the network worth joining. Refresh sponsors national, best-in-class curated resources that have long been beyond the reach of a single agency. The more valuable half comes from the partners. The local resources each enrolled agency already knows, such as the pantry down the street or the clinic that takes walk-ins, join the commons too, and they stay there in perpetuity, so that anyone in any community can be linked to them.

What turns a large collection into something a person can actually use is how each partner files what it contributes. An agency tags its own programs with what they offer, how far they reach, and where in a person's path they belong. Every other front door can then surface that program to the right person at the right moment, near enough to walk to and matched to what that person is working on now. An agency in one county adds a program on Tuesday, and a family three counties over finds it because it fits both their location and their situation. And because the people who know the ground truth are the ones keeping their own entries current, the commons is gardened rather than published. Hours change, a waitlist closes, a clinic stops taking walk-ins, and the agency nearest to it corrects the record for everyone.

> **Why the economics of access make sense.** Network-effects theory tells us that value grows with the number of users we hold. Retention economics tells us that value accrues to whoever holds the durable relationship, rather than the channel. If we hold the relationship, we compound. If the partner holds it, we are exposed.

Here is why that ordering matters. Every door we open adds people, and every person who stays makes the commons worth more to the next agency deciding whether to join. Every agency that joins adds resources and expertise, which makes the app worth more to the people already in it. Aggregation and retention are the whole engine. Past a certain density of people and partners, the network stops needing to be pushed. Agencies come because their peers are already here and their people expect it, and the resources arrive with them.

That threshold is what we are building toward, and it is the only thing on this list we have to pursue. The rest ensues. Marketplace revenue, outcome evidence, stronger grant applications, and the operational wins each agency cares about are consequences of holding a large, active, well-served population, not separate campaigns run alongside it. If we chase them directly and the population stays small, we get none of them. If we get the population right, we get all of them.

The program can pay for itself while we do it. The base platform is free, and the curated services on top of it are an allowable cost under the private, public, and restricted funding that already pays for benefits screening and enrollment. Refresh stays a software vendor: never a grantee, never the one deciding eligibility. Section 7 sets out how that works, including how an agency's own expertise becomes a service it can sell into other markets.

Everything else in this study serves that one shape, including the frameworks, the model, the metrics, the risk, and the architecture. If you remember nothing else, remember this. The door brings people in. The network keeps the relationship. The account belongs to the person. Every partner tends the commons. And past the tipping point, the commons grows itself.

SECTION 2

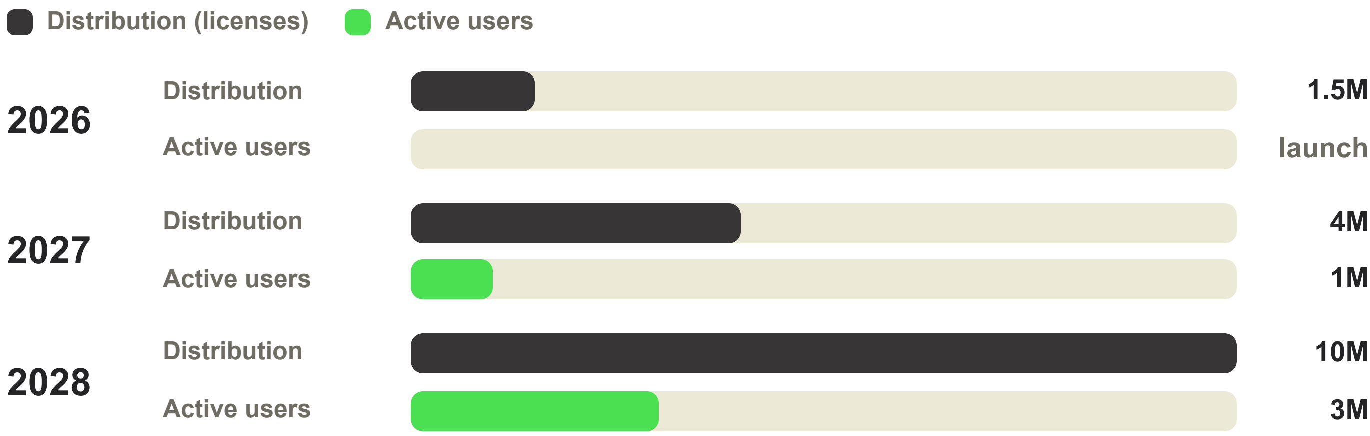
Executive summary

Own the users. Do not rent the audience.

PROBLEM	Access to help is fragmented, and value sits inside each partner's door. When a partner leaves, refuses to pay, or falls out of favor, one of our most important business models turns volatile, and the company is worth less.
INSIGHT	Give each person a **portable REACH account that sits above any single organization**. The entry door becomes an on-ramp rather than a gate, so we keep the user even when the partner changes.
MODEL	Acquire through trusted, marquee providers. Then activate, retain, monetize, and grow referrals for every user on **one shared REACH network**. Section 7 explains the funnel.
MARKET	Roughly **100 million Americans** live below the true cost of living. We enter through Goodwill, the YMCA, Catholic Charities, and their peers, with millions of licenses already within reach.
OUTCOME	A durable, defensible asset, which is **millions of active users we own and keep**. Section 8 sets out the metrics.

The three-year ramp, distribution against active users

Distribution is acquisition, the licenses in the field. Active users are what we actually keep. The two numbers, and the widening gap the model is built to close, tell the story.



Distribution scales from 1.5 million to 4 million to 10 million, while active users convert and compound to 1 million and then 3 million. The activation rate climbs from about 25 percent in 2027 to about 30 percent in 2028 as portability and rewards take hold.

SECTION 3

The frameworks it stands on

Two established frameworks explain why this plan works, and neither one is ours. That is the point. We are applying proven patterns to a sector that has never had them.

AARRR, the Pirate Metrics

The funnel we manage the business by is **AARRR**, which stands for **Acquisition, Activation, Retention, Revenue, and Referral**. Dave McClure, the founder of the accelerator 500 Startups, coined it in a 2007 talk called Startup Metrics for Pirates, and the acronym reads like a pirate's call. Its premise is simple. Stop chasing vanity numbers such as downloads, likes, and pageviews, and track the five behavioral metrics that actually predict whether a business will grow. Section 7 defines each stage in our own terms.

Aggregation Theory, own the relationship rather than the channel

The strategy is **Aggregation Theory**, which Ben Thompson set out at Stratechery in 2015. Its central claim is our thesis almost word for word. Platforms that **own the customer relationship directly**, rather than reaching people only through distributors or partners, earn compounding **network effects**. As more value flows through the platform, users stay, and the cost of acquiring the next customer falls once the platform passes critical mass.

> That sits on top of classic **network-effects theory** (a technology's value grows with its number of users) and **retention economics** (value accrues to whoever holds the durable relationship, not the channel).

The proof it works at scale

Two well-known companies run this pattern today.

American Express and card networks

Co-branded cards such as the Delta SkyMiles Card ride on the Amex network. The membership, the rewards, and the data belong to the **network**, and they are portable across every brand on it.

Shopify and Shop Pay

Every merchant owns its own storefront, yet **Shop Pay is a single portable identity** that travels with the shopper across every Shopify brand. Hundreds of millions of buyers are recognized network-wide.

REACH applies the same pattern to human services. Many trusted, branded front doors rest on one portable network and one portable account.

> **If you read only three sections, make them 9, 10, and 12.** Together they hold the crux of the plan: the risk we remove, the architecture that removes it, and the bet it creates.

SECTION 4

The North Star

Our goal is easy to state and hard to build. It is millions of individuals, reached through many trusted doors and onboarded into one platform that compounds their wellbeing for life. Providers people already trust bring them in, and technology carries them. The technology is not the point. The point is what those millions unlock once they are ours to serve, which is economies of scale for curated access that drive wellbeing outward, ring by ring.

Individual
Stabilize or thrive.

Home
The household lifted together.

Neighbor
They pull the next person in.

Community
Access and belonging compound.

Nation
Scale across every door.

Wellbeing radiates outward, from the individual to the nation.

> Winning a local brand's app is today's task, and it matters. Yet it is only acquisition and activation. It is not the goal, and we should not mistake the task for the goal.

SECTION 5

What REACH means

The name carries the mission. REACH stands for Refresh, Equity, Access, Community, and Hub. We exist to make equity and access real through a community hub that meets people where they are and stays with them.

R	E	A	C	H
Refresh	**Equity**	**Access**	**Community**	**Hub**
The platform that powers every door.	Help is not rationed by which door you came through.	One portable account to the whole graph.	Belonging and referrals no institution owns.	The place people and providers return to.

Equity and access run both ways, and this is a point the team often misses.

For people, the B2C side

Individuals reach the help they need to stabilize, to thrive, or to lift someone else, without that help being withheld at the door.

For providers, the B2B side

Nonprofits, agencies, and partners are trying to connect too, whether to help themselves, others, or their own future. The reason is the same on both sides of the network. Everyone is trying to reach, and to be reached.

SECTION 6

How people arrive, and how the door becomes the hub

People do not arrive through Refresh. They arrive through a federated, marquee, trusted provider, whether Goodwill Marion, Catholic Charities San Diego, or a local YMCA, and that provider holds their hand and onboards them. At that first moment, community means the one local nonprofit, and that is exactly right. It is how we get in quickly, on the strength of a brand people already believe in. This first stage is acquisition and activation, nothing more.

What matters is what happens next. Over time the experience widens from the single organization into the full REACH hub, a user-based view that carries the marketplace, the perks, the resources, and the community spanning every organization on the network.

1 · ENTER

The door

Onboarded by a trusted provider. Community means the local organization.

2 · ENGAGE

Programs and rewards

The organization's relationship and our rewards and perks activate them.

3 · EXPAND

The REACH hub

Marketplace, perks, and community beyond the entry organization.

4 · ENDURE

Theirs for life

A portable account. They refer others, and wellbeing compounds.

The entry door shrinks in importance as the REACH hub grows.

A concept we do not have yet, and should build. The place a person came in becomes a macro tag on their REACH identity, for example entered via Goodwill Marion. It is a tag, not a cage. The hub is REACH itself: user-based, portable, and larger than any one organization.

SECTION 7

The business model, AARRR on one shared network

Here is the whole business in a sentence. Grow, and never lose, the number of active users in our environment. Every stage of the AARRR funnel compounds only if we keep the person, which is why portability, covered in Section 10, is not a convenience. It is what makes the model work.

A

Acquisition

We ride in on marquee, trusted providers. We are introduced to the audience, and we do not have to buy it.

A

Activation

People engage through the organization's existing relationship and programs, and through our rewards and perks.

R

Retention

They come back, again and again. Because the account is portable, they do not fall off when a program ends.

R

Revenue

They buy through the marketplace, and businesses pay us for access to a trusted, engaged audience.

R

Referral

Other businesses want in because of our reach, and users invite others into access they value.

Keep the active user, and acquisition compounds into retention, revenue, and referral rather than leaking out the door.

Where the revenue comes from

With millions of people to reach and serve, the revenue is broad, and it scales on both sides of the network. It runs on the recurring platform, the commercial buyers who pay to serve or employ these populations, the marketplace, the audience lines, and grant funding, each shown below.

THE DURABLE ENGINE

Recurring platform

- SaaS setup and annual services, per site
- Medicaid program rails, a flat software fee (PMPM)

THEY PAY TO SERVE OR EMPLOY THEIR PEOPLE

Commercial buyers

- For-profit providers serving Medicaid patients, such as clinics and dental groups
- Retailers that touch benefit users, such as SNAP grocery and pharmacy, for example Walmart
- Employers of hourly or gig workers who lack benefits, giving their teams access
- Insurers, MCOs, and health systems licensing it for members

SCALES WITH USERS

Marketplace and partners

- Marketplace transactions and GMV
- Perks and rewards partner fees
- Embedded financial services, with revenue share
- Referral and lead-gen for commercial, non-reimbursable services

SCALES WITH REACH

Audience and brand

- Paid access for businesses to a trusted, engaged audience
- Sponsored content and brand partnerships, curated and labeled
- Foundation and corporate sponsorship of the platform and marketplace

SCALES WITH EXPERTISE

Decentralized managed services

- A fee per referral the network matches into another market
- Access to the tool a specialty runs on, such as debt management or expungement
- Pricing on the features a decentralized service needs, from scheduling to the toolkit

PUBLIC AND PHILANTHROPIC

Grants and public funding

- Restricted grants pay for procured technology services
- The REACH grant program on the community side

Every line stays within the compliance boundaries: no per-enrollment fees, no steering on reimbursable services, and rewards kept separate from federal enrollment.

Letting a mission expand and extend its reach

Most nonprofits can only serve the people who can reach them. Their mission stops at the county line, not because the need stops there but because the resources they rely on were curated through relationships, one introduction at a time. That was the governor on the whole sector. Once the commons is large and easy to search, the governor comes off.

An agency that is genuinely excellent at one thing can now extend that excellence into markets it will never physically serve. A person anywhere in the network raises their hand by asking to be connected with a case manager on a particular topic, books a time in the app, and meets them by video. The agency brings the expertise. Refresh brings the toolkit, the resources, and the person.

> **What that looks like in practice.** Marion, Ohio provides Employment Development Services to a participant in Northeast Texas. West Virginia runs a debt management program for someone in Sandusky, Ohio. Kentucky delivers expungement support or substance-use case management in Tennessee. None of these agencies opened an office. Each one extended the mission it already runs best.

This solves a real staffing problem. Most agencies cannot justify hiring a case manager for a single specialty, because the volume is not there locally and the specialty is not their strength. Pooling demand across the network makes that hire viable for whoever is best at it, and gives everyone else access to it. The agency with the expertise reaches further without opening a building.

Refresh earns from running the market that makes this possible, and the model has several available shapes rather than one settled answer. A fee per referral the network matches. A charge for access to the tool the specialty runs on. Or pricing on the specific features a decentralized service needs, such as scheduling, video, the shared plan, or the resource toolkit. Which of these leads, and which come bundled, is an open decision.

The marketplace also runs on three different payment routes at once, and a healthy specialty uses more than one. In the first, one agency pays another: a Goodwill in one market pays a Goodwill in another to serve its participant, and the agency delivering the service pays Refresh for the technology it runs on. In the second, philanthropy or a fund pays Refresh to facilitate and holds a retainer that pre-purchases slots with the providers, which Refresh administers for a third-party administrator fee while the person is served at no cost to them. In the third, a person applies to a service directly, and when they enroll Refresh earns a marketing fee for delivering the acquisition.

> **Why three routes rather than one.** Agency-to-agency proves the specialty is worth paying for. Sponsored capacity reaches the people whose agency cannot pay and who cannot pay themselves. Direct enrollment turns the network's own reach into demand that arrives without being sold. A specialty running on only one route is fragile.

This is a large enough idea to have its own study. See **Decentralized mission services** for the model, the naming decision, and the launch path.

How the community side is funded

The REACH grant program funds much of this work on the community side.

Recurring private, public, and restricted funding already pays for what Refresh is looking to do, namely screening people for the benefits they qualify for and helping them enroll. What has never existed is something that connects all of it without boundaries. REACH helps a nonprofit partner reach and unlock restricted funding, including Medicaid Community Health Worker rails, Connecting Kids to Coverage, and the Second Chance Act, through technology the partner competitively procures as an allowable cost. Because the base platform is free, the grant pays only for the additional curated Refresh technology services that power the work. Refresh remains a software vendor. It never becomes a grantee, and it never makes eligibility decisions, so the program can fund itself while lifting the providers as well as the people they serve.

For an agency that already receives restricted funds, REACH also helps it meet the grant's own goals for connectivity, engagement, and participant feedback, which funders increasingly expect. It captures the outcome evidence that helps a grantee renew and expand what it wins, including retention through recertification, cost-per-outcome, and audit-ready dashboards. And because Refresh provides enterprise-grade technology that a small nonprofit could never build or afford alone, it puts agencies in a position to apply for grants they could not credibly pursue before, since the technology itself strengthens the application.

> **Three funding rails.** Medicaid Community Health Worker reimbursement, Connecting Kids to Coverage, and the Second Chance Act each already pay for outreach, screening, and enrollment. REACH is procured as technology against them, not as a service that replaces the agency's own staff.

SECTION 8

How we measure it

We track AARRR on two sides at once. On the user side we count the people in our environment. On the business side we count the network and the money. We slice everything by three segments, which are active against pending against alumni, days since last login, and days since a member was onboarded.

User-based KPIs

A · Acquisition

- Active users onboarded
- New members by entry door or chapter
- Alumni
- Volunteers
- Employees
- Community members active

A · Activation

- Percent completing onboarding
- Engaging with an organization program
- Engaging with rewards or perks
- Setting a Personalized Plan
- Time to first value

R · Retention

- Returning more than once a month
- Monthly or weekly active
- Average days since last login
- Average days since onboarded
- Repeat rewards usage

R · Revenue

- Purchasing through the app
- Using the app to enter another service and collect points
- Marketplace transactions
- Points redeemed
- Value per active user

R · Referral

- Users inviting others
- Invites accepted
- Referrals per active user
- Peer-brought members

Business-based KPIs

A · Acquisition	A · Activation	R · Retention	R · Revenue	R · Referral
• Federated groups live • Chapters live • Providers integrated • Activity by group and chapter	• Businesses with an MOU • Marketing agreements • Partners live in the marketplace • Perks activated	• Active against pending against alumni orgs • Chapter and partner retention • Renewal rate	• Dollars created by business • Dollars created in total • Marketing dollars back to us • GMV and sponsorship dollars • Revenue per chapter	• Businesses wanting in, inbound • Partner-sourced leads • Businesses referring businesses

> **The point of the scoreboard is simple.** Our worth is the number of active users on the network multiplied by the dollars the network creates. It is not the count of organization logos.

SECTION 9

The risk we design out, and why we do not rent the audience READ FIRST

This is the section an executive most needs to internalize. If our leverage in the market lives inside any single nonprofit or connector, then variables we do not control decide our fate. A partner leaves. A partner refuses to pay next year. People stop wanting to work with that organization, or to walk through that door. Any of these turns one of our most important business models volatile, then obsolete, and it lowers the value of the company, because no real sustainability plan sits underneath it.

The two frameworks from Section 3 explain why the fix works. Network-effects theory tells us that value grows with the number of users we hold. Retention economics tells us that value accrues to whoever holds the durable relationship rather than the channel. If we hold the relationship, we compound. If the partner holds it, we are exposed.

If value lives in the partner	If value lives in the person and the network
Partner churn, price resistance, or a reputational falling-out with one organization can erase the audience, and the revenue with it. Our worth rises and falls on decisions made outside our walls.	Any single door can open or close and our active users remain, because the account and the REACH network are ours. Partner-dependent leverage becomes a durable, owned asset.

The rule is short. Organizations are how people come in. They are not allowed to be how our value walks out.

SECTION 10

The architecture that makes portability real

READ FIRST

It is not two apps. It is one REACH app, wearing an organization-branded skin on top and holding a wider community space inside. One decision makes the whole thing work. The person's account lives above the organization, so the chapter is an affiliation rather than a container. Detach the affiliation and the account persists.

1 · Front door, organization-branded and white-label

The organization's logo, community, and control. Local by default, with national names avoided.

Goodwill Marion · powered by REACH | CCDSD | YMCA

2 · Local experience, the Group or Team level

The curated menu, resources, coaches, and Personalized Plans, including the national, best-in-class resources Refresh sponsors and provides that most nonprofits could never afford on their own. Organization admins work here.

3 · REACH network, the platform above the organization

Everyone benefits from the REACH network. It appears inside each person's Your Resources, within their employee or employer instance, and it is available to all, automatically, in the Community view. The national resources Refresh sponsors sit here, and the local resources enrolled agencies know become part of the graph in perpetuity, so that anyone can be linked to them. No agency ever has to expose its own members or private data.

Resource graph | Marketplace | Perks | Community

Inside one branded app the person holds two views. The first is a local, organization-branded home, shown by default. The second is a REACH Community space that opens the universal layer, on the same login, at a wider aperture. That Community view is always evolving, connecting and linking new national and local resources, so that REACH becomes an app that cares, sitting in your pocket, thinking about you and building for you, ready for the moment you need it most. When the person moves on, the affiliation drops, yet the account does not.

In program

A Goodwill Marion participant, with the local view and the REACH Community, on one account.

→

Moves on

They graduate or relocate, and the affiliation expires.

→

Keeps REACH

Same login, now the neutral REACH app.

Account | Marketplace | Perks | Community

The graduate ten years on will not reopen a Goodwill app, yet they will open REACH.

SECTION 11

Branding, the local door powered by REACH

A clarification, because the history is often misremembered. The move away from Refresh@Goodwill, and away from a single national-Goodwill structure, was not driven by Goodwills refusing to have their own app. The real reason was the business model and the velocity of adoption. A federated national rollout would never have moved at the pace we need, because governance cycles, approval loops, and a single national structure slow adoption, while local, autonomous front doors launch quickly. Refresh@Goodwill was one operational reason, a vendor-first name that also treated roughly 170 independent chapters as one, and it was not the strategic driver.

Before, the operational miss

Refresh@Goodwill put the vendor first, and it implied a single national Goodwill.

After, local and portable

Goodwill Marion, Ohio, powered by REACH, puts the trusted local chapter first, with REACH as the portable network.

The Amex analogy

A Delta SkyMiles Card is co-branded, yet it rides on the Amex network. Amex does not ride on Delta. Goodwill Marion, CCDSD, and the YMCA are the co-branded cards. The neutral REACH app is the equivalent of Amex Platinum. **Everything rides on REACH, and REACH rides on none of them.**

SECTION 12

The strategic bet READ FIRST

This is fundamentally different from our current enterprise relationships. In those relationships value equals the contract, so losing the contract means losing the value. Here value equals the millions of people we onboard and keep, and that difference is the whole bet.

We have a rare, one-time opportunity to own our leverage and let it scale as we grow, rather than to build a way to lose it. Every partner we add is a channel that widens the top of the funnel. Every user we keep is an asset that compounds down it. The frameworks say this is how durable, defensible companies are built. The precedents, Amex and Shopify, say it works at scale. Our job in the public-serving division is to make it work for the people who need it most.

> **Organizations are how people come in. REACH is how they stay, for life, and for one another.**

SECTION 13

Sources and frameworks

- **AARRR, the Pirate Metrics.** Dave McClure, Startup Metrics for Pirates, 500 Startups, 2007. (inc.com; productplan.com)
- **Aggregation Theory.** Ben Thompson, Stratechery, 2015. (stratechery.com; introduction via medium.com/@hagaetc)
- **Network effects.** Sixteen Ways to Measure Network Effects, Andreessen Horowitz (a16z.com).
- **Shop Pay portable identity.** Buyer Recognition and the Shop Buyer Network, Shopify (shopify.com/enterprise/blog/shop-buyer-network).
- **Retention economics.** Value accrues to the holder of the durable customer relationship rather than the distribution channel.

Refresh Software, Inc. · REACH · Public-Serving Division. An internal business case, in draft for the executive team. Named organizations illustrate partner and provider types. Brand: Arial, cream #F8F7F0, warm-black #252427, green #4BDF52.